

about 3,000 words

Below the Reading Cut
by Douglxss Burley Johnson

My left boot found wet ballast and slid, and I caught myself on the rock wall with both palms before the cut swallowed the last of the road light.

I ran with Tasha Vorn half a stride behind and a short iron pry bar biting my right hand through the glove. The Reading cut opened ahead of us in a long throat of red shale and old railroad grade, walls rising twice the height of a barn, and the air in that throat smelled of cold stone, wet leaves, and the iron taste you get when you bite a nail. My name is Reed Holcomb. I was twenty-two that night. We had come down off the farm road above Topton because a thing in a faded trackwalker's coat had stepped out of the tree line at the pull-off and started after us without a word, and the cut was the only path that did not run us back into his hands.

"Gate at the far end," Tasha said. "We close it and we are out the other side."

"If it still closes," I said.

"It closed last October when we hauled the cooler through for the trail crew. Same pin. Same bar."

I knew the gate. Everybody who walked that abandoned Reading grade knew it. An iron frame bolted into the rock at the downhill mouth of the cut, with a drop bar that fell into a socket and a fat linchpin that held the bar home. In daylight the gate stood open so hikers and dirt bikes could pass. After dark the borough liked it shut, and the old men who still talked about the Reading Company said you did not leave a cut mouth open once the light failed, because a cut is a throat and a throat that stays open after dark invites what wants a way in.

We had left it open ourselves on the way up, chasing a sound that turned out to be a raccoon in a drainage pipe. We had meant to shut it on the walk back. Then the trackwalker stepped out of the trees with boots that hit gravel in a meter no tired man uses, and we ran downhill into the cut because the farm road was a dead end against his coat and the cut at least had a gate.

Ballast rolled under my boots. Old ties showed black in Tasha's phone light and then vanished when she killed the beam. Water ran in the ditch along the left wall, a thin cold line that talked to itself the whole length of the cut. Behind us the trackwalker's boots entered the mouth we had left open, and the sound of them came down the stone throat even and sure, the way a hammer finds the same nail.

I put the pry bar under my arm and kept running.

"Reed," Tasha said. "Your aunt's verse. Do it if you have to. Just do not stop for a sermon."

"I am not stopping," I said.

Aunt Rae had taught me the short work on her back steps the summer I turned sixteen, after a bad night on the river trail when my mouth went empty and the dark got loud. She did not give me a speech. She gave me three lines and told me to say them while my feet kept moving.

"Jesus, shut what should be shut. Hold what I cannot hold. Keep my hands on the work."

I said the first line under my breath now, boots striking ballast, pry bar knocking my ribs, and the cut walls threw the words back in a thin echo that died against shale.

Behind us the trackwalker came on. In a scrap of sky light between the walls I saw the coat, canvas gone gray, and under the brim a face that had been a man's face and was learning a different set of bones. His mouth hung open on a wet sound. His hands hung too long at the ends of the sleeves. He did not call out. He did not need to. The open gate behind him was doing the calling for both of us.

Tasha swore once, soft, the way she does when a weld fails on a job, and put on speed.

We hit a place where the cut narrowed and the left wall bulged inward over the ditch. My shoulder scraped wet stone. The pry bar rang off a bolt head left in the rock from some old Reading brace. Sparks did not show. The cold did. Behind us the trackwalker's boots took the narrow without slowing, and the wet sound in his mouth thickened into a pull, as if the open cut were feeding him air he had not earned.

"He is faster in here," Tasha said.

"Because the mouth is open," I said. "Aunt Rae said a cut that stays open after dark is a door with the latch off."

"Your aunt said a lot of things. Run."

We ran. The grade fell a little toward the downhill mouth. Ballast got thicker where washouts had dumped stone into the old bed. My left palm burned where the rock wall had taken skin on the first slide. Halfway down, a drainage culvert cut under the grade and spit ditch water into a dark pipe mouth the size of a washtub. I nearly put a boot into that hole and caught myself

on the pry bar jammed against the right wall. Tasha grabbed my jacket collar and hauled me clear without slowing her own stride.

"Watch the pipe," she said.

"I see it now."

Behind us the trackwalker took the culvert crossing without a stumble. His coat brushed the pipe rim and left a smear that looked black in the thin sky light and smelled worse than creosote when we passed the place later in memory. Ahead, painted Reading Company lettering still clung to a steel plate bolted into the shale, letters half eaten by rust, and the plate threw a pale rectangle that helped me mark distance to the gate.

Tasha's phone light flicked once more, found the iron frame ahead as a black rectangle against a lighter dark, and went off again so we would not paint a target on our backs.

A loose spike lay across a tie. I kicked it aside rather than risk a turn of the ankle. The spike rang once on stone and then the cut ate the sound. My aunt had walked this grade with me in October daylight and pointed at that same gate and said the borough kept the bar for a reason older than the trail maps. That October laugh was gone now. Wrong meter of boots ate our lead and left no room for jokes.

Short work kept going in a hard whisper that cost breath I wanted for the run.

"Jesus, shut what should be shut. Hold what I cannot hold. Keep my hands on the work."

The trackwalker answered with that wet pull of breath, closer now, and I heard his coat slap a jut of shale and tear. Cloth sound. Wrong body sound under it, like wet rope on a winch.

Tasha reached the gate first. The drop bar hung vertical in its hinge, open, the socket empty, the linchpin dangling on a short chain from the frame where some trail kid had left it after the last daylight pass. She put both hands on the bar and hauled.

The bar moved two inches and stuck. Rust and cold and a bend in the iron from years of bikes hitting it. She hauled again. The bar groaned and stuck harder.

"Reed. Bar."

I got there with the pry bar already coming up. Behind us the trackwalker cleared the narrow and the cut threw his wet breath ahead of him like weather. I set the claw of the pry under the drop bar where it met the hinge plate and threw my weight on the shaft. Iron complained. The bar jumped another three inches and hung.

"Again," Tasha said.

We drove together, her hands on the bar, my pry under the stuck place, boots planted on wet ballast. The bar came over in a hard arc and dropped toward the socket. It hit the lip of the iron cup and bounced, refused the seat, and hung crooked while the trackwalker's boots ate the last fifty yards of grade in that even wrong meter.

"Pin," I said.

"I know."

Tasha grabbed the linchpin on its chain. I got my left shoulder under the drop bar and shoved it the last inch into the socket while my right hand kept the pry wedged so the bar could not spring back. The socket took the bar with a dull iron knock that ran up the rock walls. Tasha drove the linchpin toward the hole in the bar end.

The pin hit frost and rust and stopped short of seating.

The trackwalker hit the gate.

His hands, too long in the sleeves, closed on the iron frame from our side of the bars. Fingers bent wrong at the first knuckle. The coat smelled of wet leaves and old creosote and a sweet rot that did not belong on a railroad man. His face came up against the gap above the drop

bar, and under the brim his eyes held too steady, the way a nail holds when you have already bent it and kept hammering.

"Open," he said. The voice was a trackwalker's voice rubbed down to gravel. "The cut stays open. I need the throat."

Tasha drove the linchpin a second time. Rust held the hole shut. My shoulder shook under the bar while the pry slipped a half inch on wet iron.

I could have kept talking. Short work still sat in my mouth. I shut my mouth and saved the breath for my shoulders.

Silence hit the cut like a dropped plank.

On the far side of the bars the trackwalker pulled the frame and the drop bar shuddered in the socket. Without the short work in the air his strength climbed. Against my shoulder the bar lifted a finger's width. Tasha's boots slid on ballast. On its chain the linchpin danced and would not find the hole.

"Reed," Tasha said. "Talk or shove. Pick one."

I shoved.

Both boots dug. Both hands left the pry and took the bar itself, skin on cold iron, and I drove the bar down into the socket with everything my shoulders had while Tasha lined the linchpin and hammered it with the heel of her glove. Pin metal jumped, caught the lip of the hole, and then seated with a click that ran through my teeth more than through my ears.

Drop bar locked home in the socket with a final iron settle.

He hauled on the frame a last time and the whole gate shuddered without giving. Rock bolts in the shale complained and stayed put. His face pressed the gap above the bar and the wet

sound in his mouth went thin, then sour, then broke into a cough that belonged to a man who had walked this grade in a living year and did not understand why the throat had closed on him.

I put the short work back into the air, quiet, while my hands stayed on the seated pin.

"Jesus, shut what should be shut. Hold what I cannot hold. Keep my hands on the work."

The trackwalker's pull failed. His long fingers slid off the iron. He stepped back into the throat with the locked bar between us and the walls rising behind him. He stood in ballast with the coat hanging wrong on ribs that had learned a new cage, and he looked at the seated pin the way a dog looks at a door that used to open.

"You left it open," he said. "I came because it was open."

"We closed it," I said.

"Closing costs," he said. "Your aunt knows. Tell her the cut remembers the Reading men who walked it sober and the ones who did not."

He turned without another word and walked back up the grade into the dark throat, boots even, coat torn, and the wet pull of his breath faded under the sound of the ditch water until the cut held only stone and cold and our own lungs.

Tasha slid down the gate frame until she sat on a tie end with her back to the iron. She peeled her right glove off and looked at the heel where she had hammered the pin. The leather had split. Blood showed dark in the phone light when she flicked it on for three seconds and killed it again.

"You went quiet," she said.

"Hands needed the air," I said. "It cost us. He got stronger while I shut up."

"I saw that." She flexed the split glove. "I also saw a dead railroad coat try to pull a gate out of a rock wall. I am not joining your aunt's church because a linchpin seated."

"I know."

Night wind came up from the fields below Topton and neither of us filled it. Tasha wanted a box labeled adrenaline and bad light and a story she could tell at the shop without sounding soft. I did not give her the box. My hands stayed on the linchpin, fingers checking the seat, then letting it alone.

We walked the open grade downhill toward the farm road spur where Tasha had left her truck under a walnut tree. Behind us the cut mouth held shut, drop bar home, pin seated, iron frame black against the shale. No coat reappeared at the bars. Crickets had started again in the field edge, ordinary and loud, as if the night had decided to put its regular clothes back on. I wiped blood from my left palm onto my jeans and kept the pry bar under my arm because I did not trust the dark enough to leave iron behind. At the truck the hood was cold and dew had started on the windshield. Tasha unlocked the doors with a hand that still shook once and then stopped shaking because she refuses to let fear finish a sentence. She rode us out toward the blacktop with the heater on low and her split glove in her lap.

At Aunt Rae's porch the kitchen light was still on. Rae took one look at my raw palms and Tasha's split glove and put a dish towel under my hands without asking for the long version first.

"You closed it," she said.

"Drop bar and pin," I said. "He was in the cut because we left the mouth open. He needed the throat. While I shut up to shove, he got stronger. When the pin seated and I put the short work back, he could not finish the pull."

Rae poured coffee that had sat too long and set the mug where I could reach it. She turned my hands palm up and clicked her tongue at the shale grit still in the scrapes. "A cut is a

throat. A throat with the latch off after dark is an invitation. Prayer is hands on the latch as much as words in the air. Next time you leave my gate open after a raccoon hunt, you shut it before you climb back to the farm road."

Tasha stood by the porch rail with her jacket still zipped and shook her head once, done talking for the night.

"I'll grant the stop at the gate," she said. "I will not grant a Person on the other end of your aunt's three lines before I have a bandage and a beer. Reed, text me when your hands are cleaned up. I need a new glove and a story for the shop that does not mention trackwalkers in abandoned cuts."

Tasha left, and the screen door slapped. Aunt Rae washed the grit out of my palms under cold water and checked the linchpin scrape across my thumb under the porch light. She did not ask me to preach what had happened. She handed me the towel and told me to come back in the morning to walk the cut in daylight and make sure the pin still sat true.

I am twenty-six now. I still drive the farm road above Topton when the light is low. The Reading cut still holds its red shale walls and its ditch and its iron gate at the downhill mouth. The borough painted the frame once and the paint peeled. Hikers leave the bar open in daylight and mostly remember to drop it before they go home. Tasha still sits across from me at the diner on Main and argues that prayer is a noise useful people make when a pin sticks. She will grant the stop at the gate. She will not grant a Person who answers three short lines while your shoulder is under a bar.

I keep a spare linchpin in the glove box of my truck, cut from the same stock as the one on the chain, just in case the trail kids lose the original again. On nights when the wind comes up the grade smelling of wet stone and leaf rot, I check that the drop bar still falls true the way some

people check a spare tire. I do not open the cut after dark for a dare. I do not preach the gate at Tasha. When a mouth that should be shut is hanging open and a wrong walker is already in the throat, my boots already know the grade, and my hands find the bar while my mouth finds the short work Aunt Rae taught me on the back steps.

If you ever run the abandoned Reading grade above Tipton after the light fails and hear boots that hit ballast wrong behind you, shut the downhill gate with your hands before you make a speech in the cut. The veil along that old rock throat thins in the cold hour. The pin still fits the hole.

END